

The Contemporary World - Module 1 Reviewer

Introduction to Globalization

Overview

This opening module builds the vocabulary of the course. You will learn what scholars mean by globalization, see its different aspects, and test the claim that it is a modern invention.

Learning Outcomes

- Define globalization and distinguish its economic, political, and cultural dimensions.
- Trace the historical waves of global integration.
- Evaluate the argument on whether globalization is new.
- Reflect on how globalization shapes your own daily life.

Globalization Defined

Globalization is the growing interconnection and interdependence of people, places, and institutions across the world. Scholars such as Manfred Steger describe it as an intensification of social relations that link distant localities.

It is both a process (things becoming more connected) and a set of ideas about how the world should be organized.

- Flows of goods, money, people, information, and ideas
- Time-space compression: distance matters less
- Not the same as Westernization or Americanization

Aspects of Globalization

Globalization is not a single thing. Economic globalization concerns trade, finance, and production networks. Political globalization concerns institutions and rules beyond the state. Cultural globalization concerns the spread of ideas, media, food, and lifestyles.

- Economic: trade, investment, multinational firms
- Political: UN, treaties, international law
- Cultural: media, migration, shared symbols

Is Globalization a New Phenomenon?

Historians disagree. One view holds that globalization is centuries old, pointing to the Silk Road, the spice trade, and the Spanish galleon trade linking Manila and Acapulco from 1565. Another view holds that today's speed, scale, and depth of integration are truly unprecedented.

- Archaic, early modern, modern, and contemporary waves
- Galleon Trade: an early Philippine link to global commerce
- What changed: speed, volume, and the internet

Globalization and the Individual

Global processes reach ordinary lives: the phone in your hand is designed in one country, assembled in another, and runs software written in several more. Overseas Filipino workers show how globalization moves people and money across borders, and how families feel its costs and benefits.

- Consumer, worker, and citizen roles
- Remittances and the OFW experience
- Guide question: where does your daily routine touch the world?

Review Questions

1. Explain: Globalization Defined.
2. Explain: Aspects of Globalization.
3. Explain: Is Globalization a New Phenomenon?.
4. Explain: Globalization and the Individual.